

## 2 A.M. and Everything After

*a story about the friend who never lets the last topic be the last topic*

"Okay, last topic. Then we both sleep."

She said that at 1:47 a.m. It is now past two. We have covered whether people can really change, whether my sleep schedule "counts as a personality" (it doesn't, according to her, delivered with the confidence of a supreme court), and I know with absolute certainty that neither of us is sleeping before three.

Tomorrow she will tell me this is my fault. She'll say it while smiling. Somehow that makes me lose every argument on schedule.

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I don't remember exactly how the late-night talks started, and honestly that bothers me. You'd think you'd remember the beginning of the thing that ruins your sleep schedule forever. Maybe it was exam season, when I texted her something stupid at midnight expecting a "haha" and got an entire paragraph back. At midnight. Who does that?

She does. That's her in one sentence: when the whole world gives you two-word replies, Vaishnavi gives you her actual attention — and then mocks your typing speed while doing it.

People use the word "supportive" so much it stopped meaning anything, so let me tell you what it looks like instead. It looks like the time I messed something up — details withheld, I have a reputation — and everyone hit me with that polite "it's fine, forget it." You know that kind of *fine*. The kind that closes the topic and leaves you sitting alone with it. She was the only one who didn't say it. She let me be dramatic first — she even rated my dramatics out of ten, which is rude, and which I somehow needed — and then she said one quiet sentence that made the whole thing feel smaller, and I have

never forgotten it. She probably doesn't even remember saying it. For her it was just a Tuesday. For me it was the day someone actually showed up.

Or the time I was stuck on a decision and every person I asked had a loud opinion. She heard all of my back-and-forth, then just said, "You'll regret it more if you don't. And if it goes wrong, you won't be doing it alone."

I didn't ask anyone else after that. Not because of the advice. Because of the second sentence.

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People say she's beautiful, and they're not wrong, but they mean the obvious things. I know the small ones. She laughs with her whole face, none of that polite half-smile business. She tucks her hair behind her ear when she's concentrating. She scrunches her nose when she's right about something — which is often, which she knows, because I told her once and she has weaponized it ever since. Her voice drops lower on late calls, like the hour itself has a volume setting, and I'd be lying if I said that doesn't do things to my concentration.

She calls me an idiot roughly four times a day. The concerning part is how nice it sounds. The more concerning part is that I've started collecting them like compliments.

You notice these things about exactly one person. Usually. It took me an embarrassingly long time to admit to myself why my list is so short.

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Some nights I scroll back up through our chats. No reason, nothing I'm looking for. I just land on some random Tuesday from last year where she sent seven voice notes in a row about absolutely nothing, and I listened to all of them and replied to all of them, and it was 2 a.m. again, obviously. There are entire months of my life I could reconstruct just from our conversation history.

A few times I've typed something longer. The honest version. The one that starts with her name and doesn't know where to stop. Then I delete it and send "ok anyway" like a coward. If she ever reads this, she'll know exactly which parts I mean.

There's a version of this where I say all of it plainly. But some things you say at 2 a.m., and some things you save for a blog she'll pretend she hasn't read five times.

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Here's what nobody warns you about college. You won't remember the syllabus. You'll remember who was still awake with you at 2 a.m., who noticed you were off before you said a word, who backed you when you didn't have the spine to back yourself.

For me, all of that is one person, and her name just lit up my phone, and yes — my heartbeat noticed before my brain did. I'm not investigating that. Some mysteries are nicer unsolved.

She just texted: "last topic, promise."

We both know it's a lie.

I hope it always is.

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*(And Vaishnavi — if you're reading this: hi. Yes, you're the nose-scrunch paragraph. No, I'm not taking it back.)*